

Darwin Smith

Product Designer who builds in code

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EDUCATION

University of California, San Diego

B.S. in Mathematics and Computer Science

San Diego, CA

June 2026

EXPERIENCE

Software Engineer & Product Designer

Nov 2025 – Present

Veraflux (veraflux.org), self-founded, pre-launch health-research product

San Diego, CA

- Designed and built Veraflux, a pre-launch product that turns PubMed studies into cited supplement reports personalized to age, sex, and goal. Set the brief and criteria, chose from rendered options, and measured the results.
- Color & accessibility:** rebuilt an evidence badge that used the safety red and failed WCAG AA (2.66–3.68:1) as a single-hue scale (4.69–8.50:1). Directed a 10-template contrast audit and fixed 209 light-mode failures.
- Typography:** tested four typefaces on real pages before replacing Inter, and ranked 60 fonts by letter-pair evenness for display type. Spotted fused letters a spot check missed, then confirmed them in a 676-pair sweep.
- Legibility over motion:** single-frame checks kept passing text over the animated hero, so measured contrast on inked pixels across a 90-second cycle at five widths: worst case 2.47:1 on mobile, fixed by reshaping the backdrop.
- AI-generated reports:** picked a statistic style from three renders, previewed collapsed sections in one sentence, and clarified safety labels. Kept citations per paragraph, because sentence guesses could credit the wrong study.
- Label scan:** designed the photo-to-results flow for waits of up to 5 minutes. The paywall comes before the photo, one ingredient list carries through every step, and the wait shows elapsed time, never fake progress.
- Rewrote error messages after an outage exposed raw exception text. Tone now depends on whether the problem is recoverable, retry only appears where it can work, bulk deletes ask first, and single deletes can be undone.
- Unified 8 different left edges (9–45px) across the 12 states of the signed-in search card into one 16px gutter, and made the barely visible card stand out by darkening the page behind it (1.045 to 1.151:1).
- Blocked keyboard focus inside collapsed report sections, where up to 286 hidden links and citation marks were still reachable. Moved signup validation to submit, so keyboard users can reach its error message.
- Designed a home page section that opens a realistic supplement label into real PubMed study counts per ingredient, with no score or ranking. Rows keep label order, because a sorted list would read as a verdict.
- Reviewed the argument each home page section makes and found none explained how studies are chosen, the product's main differentiator. Rebuilt the trust section around it and moved a real report above the fold.
- Changed the free tier from 1 lifetime report to 1 a month on any of 33 popular supplements plus 15 ingredient briefs, each free report labeled with its age group. Wrote a content guide for 8 contexts, from sales pages to legal copy.
- Design system:** turned type, spacing, radius, color, and motion rules into 13 CI checks whose exception lists fail once an entry goes unused. Moved 212 font sizes onto tokens with no pixel change.
- Built the Node/Express API and a Python/FastAPI pipeline with 13 LLM stages across Gemini and Claude. The server drops any citation outside the studies the model was given, and an ingredient brief costs \$0.018.
- Set up Stripe subscriptions on idempotent webhooks, usage quotas that refund on failure, and daily cost limits. Free-tier reports can only come from 165 cache keys, however many people sign up.
- Traced a crash loop during deploys (11 restarts) to an exhausted Postgres connection pooler and fixed it. Wrote baseline migrations so the database can be rebuilt from scratch.

Test Engineer

Nov 2023 – Apr 2026

SiteHive

San Diego, CA

- Ran US QA and final validation for IoT deployments as technical contact for major enterprise clients.
- Diagnosed firmware and network faults before deployment and tightened validation for recurring defects.

SKILLS

Design: User flows, interaction design, information architecture, visual and typographic design, design systems, content design and UX writing, responsive design, prototyping in code

Accessibility: WCAG 2.2 (color contrast, target size, focus order), contrast and color audits (OKLab/OKLCH)

Prototyping & tools: React, TypeScript, HTML/CSS, Framer Motion, Git, Claude Code (AI-assisted prototyping)

Engineering: Node/Express, Python/FastAPI, PostgreSQL, Stripe, Docker, LLM APIs (Gemini, Claude)